BOSTON, UNITED STATES

Isabella Stewart Gardner Museum: Masterpieces

Twenty works linked by reaching hands, held poses and the movement of fabric.



In Zorn's portrait, Isabella Stewart Gardner opens the doors with her arms spread wide. The museum's account links the moment to her return from watching fireworks in Venice. Sargent's dancer in *El Jaleo* commands another kind of gathering, her body breaking across the line of seated musicians. Neither figure needs a written explanation to establish that something has changed in the room.

Gesture provides a way through this selection without reducing Gardner's collection to a list of famous names. A child's reaching hands, a musician's turned head and a saint attending to another body carry different kinds of attention. Even the drawings of buildings and costumes ask how a surface directs movement, or preserves the trace of someone looking.

Artline selected these works from documented museum holdings. The selection is independent of the museum, and individual works may be on loan or off display. Dates and attributions retain the qualifications in the linked records.

Explore this selection in Artline

See the selected works alongside books and events from their period, or compare when the artists lived. The books and events provide context, not evidence of direct influence. Works without confirmed dates remain in this guide.

Artworks in context Who lived when?

artlines.org/guides/isabella-stewart-gardner

The selection · 20

1. The Abduction of Europa
   Titian · 1559 - 1562
2. The Story of Lucretia
   Sandro Botticelli · 1496 - 1504
3. El Jaleo
   John Singer Sargent · 1882
4. Hercules
   Piero della Francesca · 1465
5. The Presentation of the Christ Child in the Temple
   Giotto di Bondone · 1320
6. Madonna and Child with an Angel
   Sandro Botticelli · 1470
7. Harmony in Blue and Silver: Trouville
   James Abbott McNeill Whistler · 1865
8. The Omnibus
   Anders Zorn · 1892
9. Isabella Stewart Gardner in Venice
   Anders Zorn · 1894
10. Juana of Austria with a Young Girl
    Sofonisba Anguissola · 1561
11. The Roman Tower, Andernach
    J. M. W. Turner · 1817
12. The Casa Loredan, Venice
    John Ruskin · 1850
13. Love's Greeting
    Dante Gabriel Rossetti · c. 1861
14. Ida Rubinstein as Saint Sebastian
    Léon Bakst · 1911
15. Anna Pavlova in Oriental Fantasy
    Léon Bakst · 1913
16. Charles Martin Loeffler
    John Singer Sargent · 1903
17. A Tent in the Rockies
    John Singer Sargent · c. 1916
18. Incensing the Veil
    John Singer Sargent · 1880
19. A Young Lady of Fashion
    Attributed to Paolo Uccello · Early 1460s
20. Morning Toilet
    Anders Zorn · 1888

01 / 20

The Abduction of Europa

Titian

1559 - 1562 · Oil on canvas · Isabella Stewart Gardner Museum



Titian. Abduction of Europa. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/titian/rape-of-europe-1562 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

Europa clings to the white bull as it moves through the water. Raised limbs and loose cloth keep her body from finding a secure position. Titian's colour can make the scene visually luxurious, but its action remains an abduction. Attending to the woman's exposed, unstable posture prevents the beauty of the surface from becoming an excuse to overlook the violence.

Object source · Open artwork

02 / 20

The Story of Lucretia

Sandro Botticelli

1496 - 1504 · Tempera on panel · Isabella Stewart Gardner Museum



Sandro Botticelli. The Story of Lucretia. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/sandro-botticelli/the-story-of-lucretia-1504 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

Botticelli distributes episodes across an architectural setting instead of choosing one instant. The body and gesturing crowd in the central square give the Roman story a public consequence. Buildings hold the separate actions together, allowing the eye to move between private injury and collective response. The painting's narrative depends on reading across space, not merely identifying its central figure.

Object source · Open artwork

03 / 20

El Jaleo

John Singer Sargent

1882 · Isabella Stewart Gardner Museum



John Singer Sargent. El Jaleo. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

Light from below catches the dancer's skirt and arms while leaving her face in shadow. Sargent sets that sharply angled body against the seated musicians' repeated positions. The large shadow extends the movement onto the wall. At more than three metres wide, the painting gives a bodily performance ample room, even as the figures remain pressed against a shallow background.

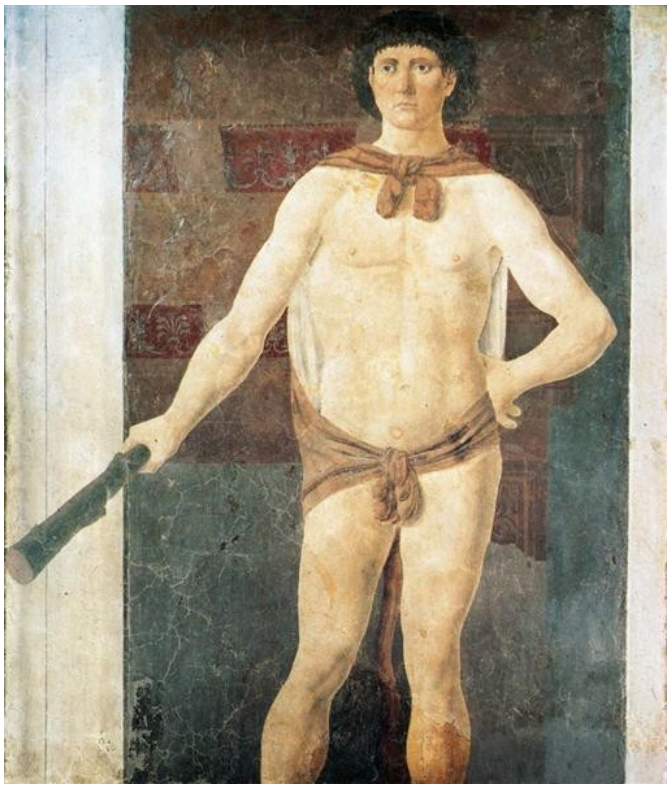
Object source · Open artwork

04 / 20

Hercules

Piero della Francesca

1465 · Isabella Stewart Gardner Museum



Hercules. WikiArt; Piero della Francesca. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Public domain

The club identifies Hercules, but Piero della Francesca shows no feat in progress. The nearly nude body stands firmly within a shallow architectural opening, filling the field through its proportions rather than through action. After Europa's instability, this planted figure offers a useful contrast: strength can be represented as the capacity to remain still, without requiring a defeated opponent.

Object source · Open artwork

05 / 20

The Presentation of the Christ Child in the Temple

Giotto di Bondone

1320 · Tempera on panel · Isabella Stewart Gardner Museum



The Presentation of the Infant Jesus in the Temple. WikiArt; Giotto di Bondone. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Public domain

The adults reach across the small altar while the infant responds with his own body. Giotto gives sacred recognition an immediate physical scale: the distance between extended hands. The pointed canopy and compact architecture arrange the participants into separate places, but the reaching child interrupts that order. The event can be followed through his movement before every figure has been named.

Object source · Open artwork

06 / 20

Madonna and Child with an Angel

Sandro Botticelli

1470 · Tempera on wood · Isabella Stewart Gardner Museum



Sandro Botticelli. Madonna and Child with an Angel. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/sandro-botticelli/madonna-and-child-with-an-angel · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

Inclined heads bring attention towards the child, while the supporting hands make that attention tangible. Botticelli leaves only a narrow opening onto the landscape behind the close group. The panel's devotional purpose does not cancel the ordinary mechanics of care: a small body must be held, and the arrangement of those holding it supplies the painting's quiet activity.

Object source · Open artwork

07 / 20

Harmony in Blue and Silver: Trouville

James Abbott McNeill Whistler

1865 · Oil on canvas · Isabella Stewart Gardner Museum



Harmony in Blue and Silver: Trouville. WikiArt; James Abbott McNeill Whistler. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Public domain

The small standing figure briefly interrupts the beach's horizontal divisions. Whistler gives sea, shore and sky closely related tones, allowing their differences to remain slight. The person helps measure the distance without taking possession of the scene. This restraint explains the title's emphasis on colour: the view holds together through tonal relationships more than through an event on the beach.

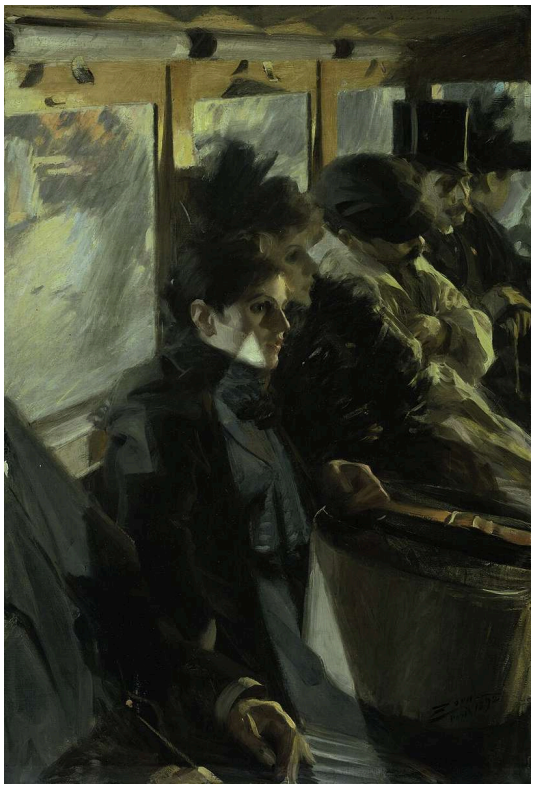
Object source · Open artwork

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The Omnibus

Anders Zorn

1892 · Isabella Stewart Gardner Museum



Anders Zorn. The Omnibus. Image credit: Anders Zorn; Isabella Stewart Gardner Museum. https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Anders_Zorn_-_The_Omnibus_-_P3e1_-_Isabella_Stewart_Gardner_Museum.jpg. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame resize and JPEG compression; applicable ShareAlike terms retained. · Public domain

The passengers share a confined vehicle without becoming a unified group. Window light selects faces and pieces of clothing while other bodies remain partly hidden. Zorn makes the practical condition of public transport visible: proximity does not necessarily produce an exchange. The gaps in attention matter as much as the shortage of physical space between the sitters.

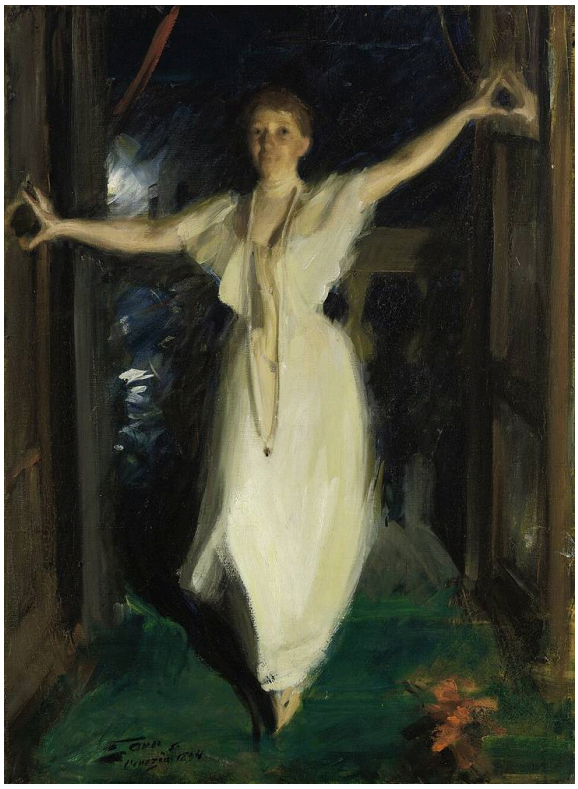
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: P3e1

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Isabella Stewart Gardner in Venice

Anders Zorn

1894 · Isabella Stewart Gardner Museum



Anders Zorn. Isabella Stewart Gardner in Venice. Image credit: Anders Zorn; Isabella Stewart Gardner Museum. https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Anders_Zorn_-_Isabella_Stewart_Gardner_in_Venice_-_P17e10_-_Isabella_Stewart_Gardner_Museum.jpg. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame resize and JPEG compression; applicable ShareAlike terms retained. · Public domain

Gardner's outstretched arms reach towards the doors on either side of her. Zorn places the lit figure between the room and the dark balcony beyond. According to her husband's diary, the moment followed her watching fireworks and inviting the guests outside. The portrait preserves an invitation in progress, replacing the conventional sitter's stillness with an act that reorganises the company.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: P17e10

10 / 20

Juana of Austria with a Young Girl

Sofonisba Anguissola

1561 · Isabella Stewart Gardner Museum



Sofonisba Anguissola. Portrait of Juana of Austria with a Young Girl. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The difference in height gives the two figures an immediate hierarchy, reinforced by their formal clothes. Sofonisba Anguissola keeps their expressions restrained against a dark setting. Small contacts and the child's placement must therefore carry much of the relationship. The portrait records a connection without offering the easy familiarity that a smile or a shared activity might supply.

Object source · Open artwork

11 / 20

The Roman Tower, Andernach

J. M. W. Turner

1817 · Isabella Stewart Gardner Museum



J. M. W. Turner. The Roman Tower, Andernach. Image credit: J. M. W. Turner; Source credit: Isabella Stewart Gardner Museum. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The tower provides a strong upright among the riverside buildings, but Turner's broad sky denies it sole command of the view. Boats and people keep the water active beneath it. The monument belongs to weather, traffic and changing light. Its solidity becomes more noticeable because so much around it cannot be fixed in place.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: P1e12

12 / 20

The Casa Loredan, Venice

John Ruskin

1850 · Isabella Stewart Gardner Museum



John Ruskin. The Casa Loredan, Venice. Image credit: John Ruskin; Source credit: Isabella Stewart Gardner Museum. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Some architectural passages receive colour and detail; others remain lightly outlined on the sheet. Ruskin's selectiveness records a way of studying the façade rather than an evenly complete survey. Follow the changes in attention across arches and ornament. What remains unfinished can help distinguish the details he needed to examine from the surrounding forms needed only to locate them.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: P17e32

13 / 20

Love's Greeting

Dante Gabriel Rossetti

c. 1861 · Isabella Stewart Gardner Museum



Dante Gabriel Rossetti. Love's Greeting. Image credit: Dante Gabriel Rossetti; Source credit: Isabella Stewart Gardner Museum. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Rossetti gives the closely joined figures little space apart from the ornament surrounding them. Flowers, patterns and the inscription are not a neutral border to a fully independent scene; they help set its concentrated register. Gesture passes into decoration. The encounter is presented as something framed and made precious, rather than as a moment casually glimpsed in ordinary surroundings.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: P1w8

14 / 20

Ida Rubinstein as Saint Sebastian

Léon Bakst

1911 · Isabella Stewart Gardner Museum



Léon Bakst. Ida Rubinstein as Saint Sebastian. Image credit: Léon Bakst; Source credit: Isabella Stewart Gardner Museum. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Proportional resize and JPEG compression; full source frame retained. · Public domain

The broad blue cloak makes the figure readable as a silhouette before its patterned detail comes into focus. Bakst sets it against contrasting red clothing on an otherwise open sheet. A stage costume has to operate at several distances. Here the large shapes establish the role, while their internal decoration gives the eye more to discover when brought closer.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 3.1.o.91

15 / 20

Anna Pavlova in Oriental Fantasy

Léon Bakst

1913 · Isabella Stewart Gardner Museum



Léon Bakst. Anna Pavlova in the Ballet 'Oriental Fantasy'. Image credit: Léon Bakst; Source credit: Isabella Stewart Gardner Museum. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Proportional resize and JPEG compression; full source frame retained. · Public domain

Extended arms, a short spreading skirt and a trailing scarf make the costume continue the dancer's movement. Bakst does not design clothes for a motionless mannequin. The opposing directions of the feet and limbs show how fabric might enlarge an action. The title's imagined setting belongs to theatrical fantasy, not to a reliable account of a particular culture's dress.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 3.1.o.92

16 / 20

Charles Martin Loeffler

John Singer Sargent

1903 · Isabella Stewart Gardner Museum



Τζον Σίνγκερ Σάρτζεντ. Charles Martin Loeffler. Image credit: John Singer Sargent; Source credit: https://www.gardnermuseum.org/experience/collection/10870. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The partly visible instrument identifies the musician without turning the portrait into a performance. Sargent lets the pale face turn away from the viewer, while dark clothing holds most of the body back. Compare this reserved arrangement with *El Jaleo*: music can enter a painting through an occupied stage, or through the presence of someone who is not playing.

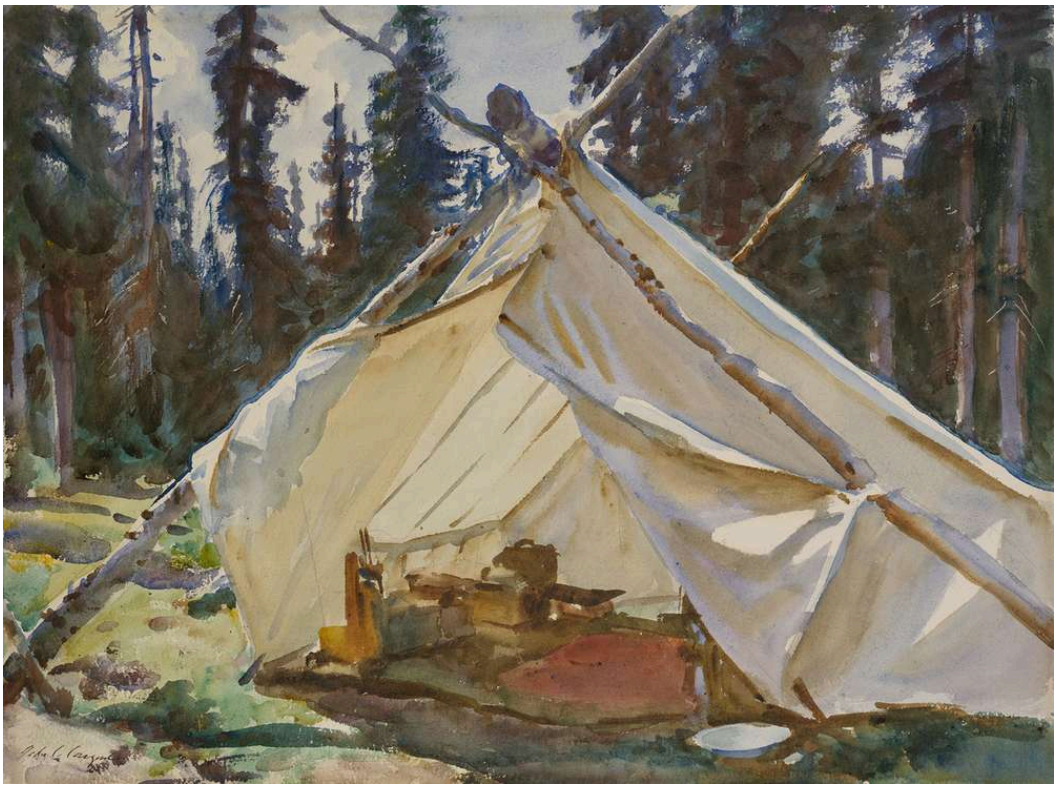
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: P1w6

17 / 20

A Tent in the Rockies

John Singer Sargent

c. 1916 · Isabella Stewart Gardner Museum



Τζον Σίνγκερ Σάρτζεντ. A Tent in the Rockies. Image credit: John Singer Sargent; Source credit: https://www.gardnermuseum.org/experience/collection/10882. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Sunlit fabric becomes another changing surface among the trees. Sargent's broad strokes do not isolate the tent as a rigid object set against the forest; they connect its light and shade with the surrounding ground. The open entrance makes its temporary shelter apparent. Habitation here depends on a thin, permeable boundary rather than on the weight of walls.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: P3w17

18 / 20

Incensing the Veil

John Singer Sargent

1880 · Isabella Stewart Gardner Museum



Τζον Σίνγκερ Σάρτζεντ. Incensing the Veil. Image credit: John Singer Sargent; Source credit: Isabella Stewart Gardner Museum. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Hanging fabric, pale clothing and smoke interfere with a clear separation of figure and room. Sargent makes partial visibility the condition of the scene. Instead of searching for a single decisive outline, follow the layers through which the body becomes legible. The action named in the title affects how it can be seen: the incense also changes the air around it.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: P3w33

19 / 20

A Young Lady of Fashion

Attributed to Paolo Uccello

Early 1460s · Isabella Stewart Gardner Museum



Paolo Uccello. A Young Lady of Fashion. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The strict profile keeps the sitter's gaze outside any exchange with the viewer. Pearls and the patterned sleeve offer abundant information about her presentation, while the face remains bounded and reserved. Attributed to Paolo Uccello, the portrait gives social appearance an exact material form without claiming to reveal a private personality beneath it.

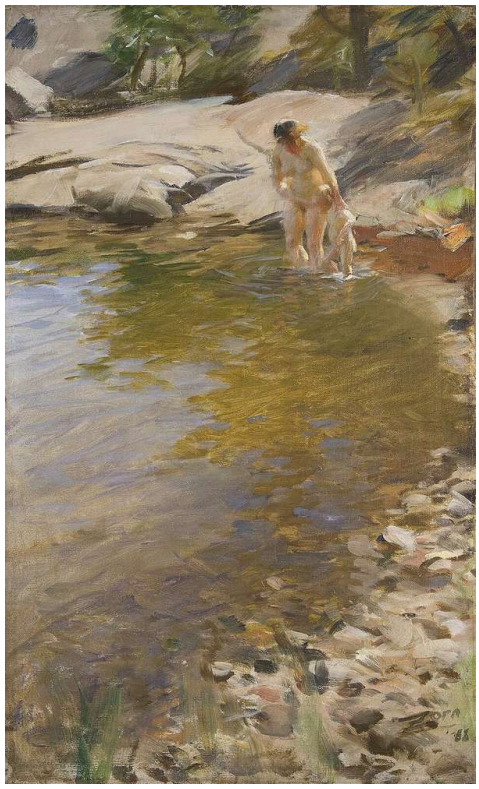
Object source · Open artwork

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Morning Toilet

Anders Zorn

1888 · Isabella Stewart Gardner Museum



Anders Zorn. Morning Toilet. Image credit: Anders Zorn; Isabella Stewart Gardner Museum. https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Anders_Zorn_-_Morning_Toilet_-_P25e13_-_Isabella_Stewart_Gardner_Museum.jpg. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame resize and JPEG compression; applicable ShareAlike terms retained. · Public domain

The woman's bent posture keeps her activity readable amid the broken reflections. Zorn puts a private act beside shallow water and rocks, where the surrounding light refuses to remain still. The figure neither dominates the landscape nor disappears into it. Her small, concentrated movement supplies a point of attention within the more dispersed activity of the water.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: P25e13

Let the room remain part of the work

The Gardner Museum's settings can affect a painting's scale and associations as strongly as a neighbouring picture. Give an arrangement time before isolating its individual objects. This selection follows themes rather than a physical route; use current museum information for access and display, and remember that works on paper may not be available continuously.

Further reading

A Treatise on Painting

Leonardo da Vinci; translated by John Francis Rigaud · Read free · English

Leonardo’s notes on gesture and the arrangement of figures offer questions to bring to the Italian paintings. Compare the still bodies in Piero’s Hercules and Botticelli’s Madonna with the many intersecting actions in The Story of Lucretia.

Museum website · Official collection guide

Sources and visitor information checked: 2026-10-12